Deep Tech — when the product is still in the lab

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What changes: your riskiest assumption may be technical — but the commercial clock still runs. You validate demand for the OUTCOME before the tech is ready, exactly like Dropbox validated with a video.

Your wallet-equivalents (honest hierarchy): paid feasibility study/pilot from an industrial partner (best — real money) > LOI with concrete numbers and conditions (good — conditional wallet) > EXIST/grant awarded (money, but a jury is not a customer — label it) > “strategic interest” emails (signal only). The revenue bars: one €3k paid feasibility study can clear multiple weekly bars — deal size compensates count.

Your ladder translation: M04 landing page: a technical one-pager + outcome demo video sent to 20 named industry contacts, threshold on meeting-requests. M06 prototype: simulation/benchmark that proves the CLAIM: build the smallest thing that tests the physics. M07 monkey-first is your module — name the assumption that kills it. M12: your funding path skews grants/strategic (Celonis started on EXIST).

Your traps: “we’ll validate after the paper”, grant-chasing as revenue substitute (two grants is not PMF), pilots that never convert because success criteria were never agreed (M09 pilot structure applies doubly).

Kill criteria that bite: no industrial partner will pay even a token feasibility fee after 10 asks · the technical monkey fails its own benchmark twice · every “customer” wants it free until it’s perfect.